

PROJECT REPORT

Indigenous Digital Archive Pilot

Community-Controlled Digital Collection of Nomadic Heritage

Beyond Borders

Indigenous Young Women-Led Collective | Northern Kenya ASAL

Implementation Period: 2024

Locations: Turkana and Samburu Counties

This report documents a community-led pilot that trained indigenous young women to document, curate and control digital records of nomadic cultural heritage. All archives remain on local devices under community governance.

1. Executive Summary

In 2024, Beyond Borders implemented the Indigenous Digital Archive Pilot in Turkana and Samburu counties. The pilot trained 25 indigenous young women in digital storytelling and community archiving methods. Participants documented more than 40 oral histories and cultural practices, creating what is understood to be the first community-controlled digital collection of nomadic heritage in the region. Unlike extractive documentation projects, all materials are stored on local devices and governed by community archivists according to indigenous protocols around sacred knowledge.

The pilot responded directly to a long history of external researchers and agencies extracting cultural knowledge without consent or local ownership. It demonstrated that indigenous young women can design and manage digital heritage systems that respect cultural boundaries while building technical skills relevant to low-connectivity ASAL contexts.

25	40+	2	Local devices only
Young women trained	Oral histories & practices documented	Counties reached	Storage model

2. Background and Rationale

Northern Kenya’s pastoralist communities hold rich oral histories, ecological knowledge, songs and cultural practices that have been systematically extracted by external researchers, NGOs and media. Materials are frequently stored in Global North institutions with little or no community control over access, use or interpretation. At the same time, digital tools that could support local memory work are rarely designed for ASAL realities: intermittent connectivity, limited electricity, shared devices and low smartphone ownership outside towns.

Beyond Borders, an indigenous young women-led collective formed in 2022, identified the need for a practical alternative: training young women from Turkana and Samburu communities to document heritage themselves, store it locally, and apply indigenous protocols that distinguish sacred knowledge from material that can be shared. The pilot was designed as a proof of concept for community-controlled digital archives rather than a large-scale digitisation project.

3. Objectives

Primary objectives were to:

- Build practical digital storytelling and archiving skills among indigenous young women from Turkana and Samburu communities.
- Document a first set of oral histories and cultural practices under community direction.
- Establish local-device storage and simple access protocols that keep sensitive material offline and under community control.
- Test whether a modest, offline-first approach could generate trust among elders and participants after years of extractive documentation.
- Identify young women ready to continue as community archivists and peer trainers.

4. Approach and Methods

4.1 Participant selection and preparation

Twenty-five young women (ages approximately 18–28) from Turkana and Samburu communities were selected through existing community networks and prior engagement with Beyond Borders. Priority was given to women already active in local youth or women’s groups and those with basic literacy in local languages or Kiswahili. No prior technical expertise was required.

4.2 Training content

Training combined practical digital skills with cultural protocols. Sessions covered:

- Basic device handling, audio recording and simple video on available phones and shared tablets.
- Interview and storytelling techniques respectful of elders and gender dynamics.
- Consent processes, including collective and individual consent for recording and future use.
- Distinguishing sacred or restricted knowledge from material that may be shared more widely.
- Local file organisation, basic metadata (who, where, when, language, sensitivity level) and offline backup.
- Discussion of digital colonialism and why local control of archives matters.

Training was delivered in short residential or clustered sessions to accommodate pastoralist mobility and household responsibilities. Content was adapted to local languages where possible.

4.3 Documentation and storage

Participants conducted interviews and recordings within their own communities under the guidance of the core team and cultural advisors. Materials were stored on local devices (phones, tablets and external drives managed by the collective). No content was uploaded to commercial cloud services. Access levels were agreed with elders and the young women archivists: some materials remain fully offline and restricted; others may be used for community education or limited external sharing with explicit consent.

5. Key Results and Outputs

The pilot produced both tangible outputs and relational outcomes:

Tangible outputs

- 25 indigenous young women trained in digital storytelling and community archiving.
- More than 40 oral histories and cultural practices documented (songs, ecological knowledge, historical narratives, women's practices).
- A first community-controlled digital collection stored exclusively on local devices.
- Simple classification and access protocols co-developed with elders and participants.

Relational and capacity outcomes

- Increased trust among some elders who had previously refused external documentation projects.
- Identification of a smaller group of participants ready to act as ongoing community archivists and peer trainers.
- Stronger internal understanding within Beyond Borders of the practical requirements of offline-first heritage work in ASAL settings.
- Clear demonstration that young indigenous women can lead technical and cultural aspects of digital memory work.

6. Challenges and Lessons Learned

Several challenges shaped the pilot and informed future design:

- Device and power constraints: Shared phones, limited battery life and scarce charging points required careful planning of recording sessions and frequent local backups.
- Connectivity assumptions: Any workflow that assumed regular internet access failed. Offline-first storage and occasional physical transfer of files proved more reliable.
- Trust recovery: Initial suspicion from elders was expected given prior extractive experiences. Consistent presence, transparent consent, and visible community control of devices were essential.
- Sacred knowledge boundaries: Not all material can or should be digitised. Clear protocols for what remains offline and restricted are as important as the technical system.
- Time and mobility: Pastoralist movement and household labour limited continuous participation; clustered and residential formats worked better than weekly meetings.

Key lesson: technical training alone is insufficient. Trust, cultural protocols and realistic offline design determine whether a digital archive is adopted and sustained.

7. Contribution to Beyond Borders' Work

The pilot established the foundation for the Digital Heritage working circle and provided practical experience that now informs the collective's longer-term approach to community-controlled archives, offline-first tools and indigenous feminist tech. It also generated a small cohort of young women with demonstrated capacity to train others and manage local collections.

8. Looking Ahead

Future work will deepen the existing collection, strengthen community archivist skills, and explore lightweight offline platforms that remain under local control. The emphasis will continue to be quality of process and community ownership rather than volume of digitised material. Any expansion will prioritise solar-supported local storage and clear protocols that protect sacred knowledge.

This report is intended for internal reflection, partner learning and accountable documentation of community-led work. It does not claim to represent the full diversity of Turkana or Samburu heritage, nor does it replace ongoing community governance of the archives.